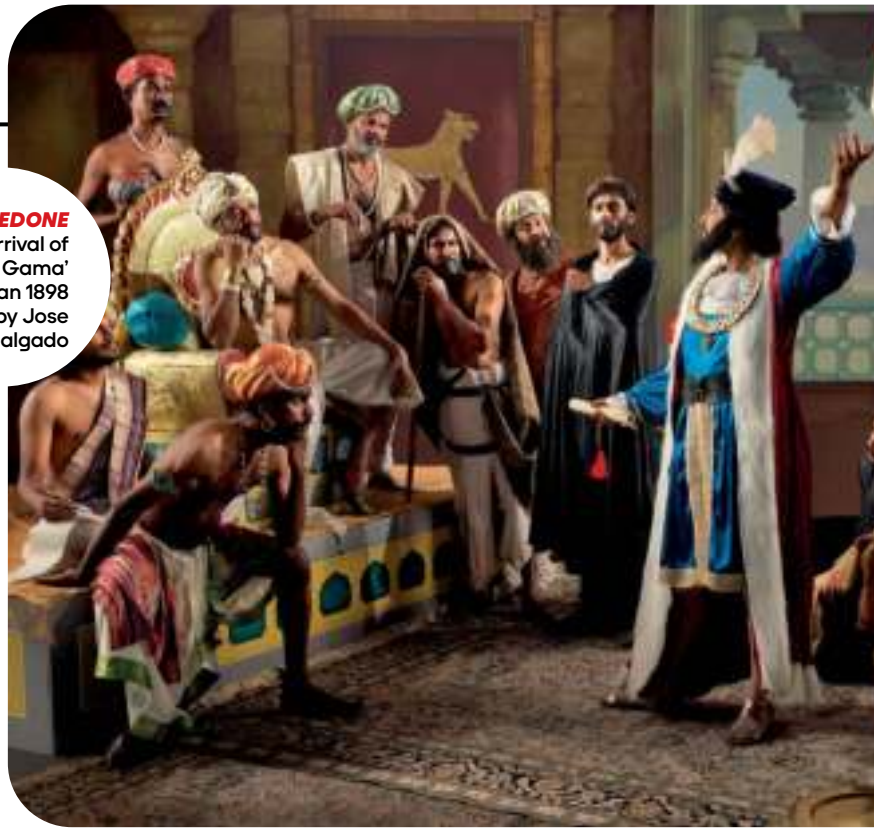


ROBES REDONE 'The Arrival of Vasco da Gama' (2014), after an 1898 painting by Jose Veloso Salgado

"The most entertaining artist-iconoclast of contemporary Indian art." Read any article or write-up on Pushpamala N. and chances are that you will come across this line to describe the photo and video performance artist, sculptor, writer and curator. In fact, her own website uses the line in her biography. Ask the artist about its origins and she says she doesn't recall who said it first, but agrees with it enough to use it in her bio. "I use a lot of humour in my work and I want to be entertaining. My work is iconoclastic because I'm trying to deconstruct icons and critique the mainstream," she says.

Her exhibition *Dressing Up: Pushpamala N* is currently on display at CHANEL Nexus Hall in Tokyo, marking her first major solo exhibition in Japan. Earlier this year, she showcased three of her works—including 'Mother India', 'Avega—The Passion', and 'The Arrival of Vasco da Gama'—at Kyotographie 2025 in Japan. The current exhibition features three of her celebrated series 'Phantom Lady or Kismet', 'Return of the Phantom Lady', and 'The Navarasa Suite', which explore archetypal female characters inspired by the 'Golden Age' of Indian cinema, with the works drawing from mythology, folklore and popular culture, and examining how visual language shapes cultural memory and national identity.

Interestingly, 'Phantom Lady' was Pushpamala's first 'photo-performance' work, which she worked on between 1996 and 1998. Shot in Mumbai, the 25 black-and-white photographs were inspired by popular Hindi films that depicted the masked character of Fearless Nadia. "I was always a fan of Fearless Nadia and thought I could have some fun with it. I got a 'hunter-wali' outfit stitched and asked (photojournalist) Meenal Agarwal to shoot me in it," she recalls. The early shots excited her and she decided to develop them further into a story. In these photographs, the artist plays two roles—that of the Phantom Lady, who is a Zorro-like character, and the vamp, who is the lost twin sister. "I chose a psychological kind of style for the photographs, which was film noir. There is a play of light and shade and people have often remarked that my work is sculptural," she says.

THE NEW SHOW, INSPIRED BY FEMALE CHARACTERS OF INDIAN CINEMA'S 'GOLDEN AGE', IS ON VIEW AT CHANEL NEXUS HALL, TOKYO, UNTIL AUG. 17

This isn't surprising, considering the multidisciplinary artist initially trained in sculpting at MS University of Baroda and has won numerous awards for her sculptural pieces.

'Phantom Lady' was a photography and video project that started as a lark for a show on Indian cinema but soon turned into an interest that only grew with time. "It suits a lot of my interests—I like to use humour and storytelling in my work," says Pushpamala.

It is not just popular culture that inspires her, though. A lot of the humour also stems from daily life and her observations. Popular imagery is sourced from films, calendars, postcards, photographs, posters and advertisements. She uses sources from theatre and art history as well. "I'm interested in history and memory because I want to understand the present," she says. Pushpamala is particularly interested in the 19th century because she believes it was a significant period in history that marked a multitude of things—colonialism, the nationalist movement, imagery